

RKC Minorwood

Once a minor has been decided on as the trump suit — either by signaling a fit (1♣-2♣) or by a jump raise (1♣-1♥-3♣) — a bid of 4 of the minor initiates slam investigation by asking for keycards (the 4 aces plus the king of the agreed minor, 5 “keycards” total). Responder answers up the line, using the next available suit above the trump suit as the first step, and continuing step by step from there — each step showing a different keycard count.

Step	Response	Meaning	Next-suit-up asks
1	4♦	1 or 4 keycards	4♥ = Queen ask
2	4♥	0 or 3 keycards	4♠ = Queen ask
3	4♠	2 keycards, without the ♣Q	5♦ = King ask
4	4NT	2 keycards, with the ♣Q	5♦ = King ask

At any point, instead of asking further, the asker can simply bid 4NT or 5♣ (whichever step wasn’t used as the response) to sign off — “I’ve heard enough, let’s stop here.”

If the asker does continue, the next bid up asks about the trump queen (after steps 1 or 2) or about side-suit kings (after steps 3 or 4, since holding or lacking the queen is already known). Responder answers those asks the same way — up the line, one suit at a time — with the cheapest available bid showing possession; any suit skipped past is automatically denied, since the rule is always to bid the cheapest step that’s actually true. A dedicated denial bid sits at the bottom of each ladder (5♣ for no queen; 6♣ for no side kings). Asking again after a king is shown becomes a grand slam try in that specific suit.

Ask	Response	Meaning
Queen ask (e.g., 4♥ after step 1)	5♣	No queen — deny/sign-off
	4NT	Queen, no side king
	cheapest available side king (4♠ / 5♦ / 5♥)	Queen, plus that king — any step bid past denies the king(s) below it (never shows the ♣K here — already known)
	5NT (optional)	Queen plus 2 kings — trades identity for speed, since it doesn’t say which 2
King ask (always 5♦)	6♣	No side kings — deny/sign-off

Ask	Response	Meaning
	cheapest available king (5♥ / 5♠ / 5NT (♦))	Holds that king — any step bid past denies the king(s) below it
Either ask, follow-up	Asker bids again after a king is shown	Grand slam try — “bid 7 if you have that specific king”

The exact same structure applies when diamonds is the agreed trump suit — same steps, same logic, same follow-ups. The only difference is that because diamonds outranks clubs in the bidding, the entire ladder gets pushed up one slot: every step response, and every subsequent ask, lands one bid higher than its clubs equivalent. This also means there’s a bit less room to maneuver before hitting the 5-level compared to clubs — part of why Minorwood is especially valuable in diamonds, where plain Blackwood could otherwise shove you past a safe stopping point.

Step	Response	Meaning	Next-suit-up asks
1	4♥	1 or 4 keycards	4♠ = Queen ask
2	4♠	0 or 3 keycards	5♣ = Queen ask
3	4NT	2 keycards, without the ♦Q	5♣ = King ask
4	5♣	2 keycards, with the ♦Q	5♥ = King ask

(Sign-off: 4NT or 5♦, whichever wasn’t used as the actual response.)

One structural quirk worth flagging: unlike clubs, where the King ask always lands on the same bid (5♦) regardless of whether it came from step 3 or step 4, diamonds’ King ask is not constant — it’s 5♣ coming from step 3, but 5♥ coming from step 4. That’s because step 4’s response (5♣) is itself a real suit bid (unlike clubs’ step 4, which was 4NT and consumed no suit slot), so it uses up a rung of the ladder that the King ask then has to climb past.

Ask	Response	Meaning
Queen ask (e.g., 4♠ after step 1)	5♦	No queen — deny/sign-off
	4NT	Queen, no side king
	cheapest available side king (5♣ / 5♥ / 5♠)	Queen, plus that king — any step bid past denies the king(s) below it (never shows the ♦K here — already known)
	5NT (optional)	Queen plus 2 kings

Ask	Response	Meaning
King ask (e.g., 5♣ after step 3)	5♦	No side kings — deny/sign-off
	cheapest available king (5♥ / 5♠ / 5NT (♣))	Holds that king — any step bid past denies the king(s) below it
Either ask, follow-up	Asker bids again after a king is shown	Grand slam try — “bid 7 if you have that specific king”